

SENTRY-IDS

USING SNORT AND WIRESHARK

Submitted

*In Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements
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In

Cyber Security and Digital Forensics

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We declare that this written submission represents our work and ideas in our own words, and where others' ideas or words have been included, we have adequately cited and referenced the original sources. We also declare that we have adhered to all principles of academic honesty and integrity and have not misrepresented, fabricated, or falsified any idea, data, fact, or source in our submission.

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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that Ashish and Dhruva have carried out the research work presented in this report entitled "DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION OF A NETWORK INTRUSION DETECTION SYSTEM (IDS) USING SNORT AND WIRESHARK" for the award of the Internship Certificate in Cyber Security and Digital Forensics from Madan Mohan Malaviya University of Technology, Gorakhpur, under my supervision. The report embodies the results of original work and studies carried out by the students themselves, and the contents of the report do not form the basis for the award of any other degree or certificate to the candidates or to anybody else.

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Ashish Dubey

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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

Introduction

With the rapid growth of the Internet, cloud computing, mobile devices, and enterprise networks, cybersecurity has become one of the most critical concerns for individuals and organizations. Every day, millions of cyberattacks such as malware infections, phishing attacks, ransomware, Distributed Denial-of-Service (DDoS) attacks, SQL injection, brute-force attacks, and unauthorized access attempts target computer systems worldwide. Traditional security mechanisms such as firewalls, antivirus software, and access control systems provide the first line of defense against these attacks. However, these security mechanisms alone are not sufficient to detect sophisticated or insider attacks that bypass perimeter security.

An Intrusion Detection System (IDS) is a cybersecurity solution designed to monitor network traffic and host activities to identify suspicious behaviour, policy violations, and malicious attacks. An IDS continuously analyses packets, system logs, and user activities to detect abnormal events and generate alerts for administrators. Unlike firewalls, which prevent unauthorized traffic from entering a network, an IDS focuses on monitoring, detecting, and reporting security incidents.

The primary objective of an IDS is to improve network security by providing early detection of cyber threats before they cause significant damage. Modern IDS solutions employ signature-based detection, anomaly-based detection, and hybrid detection techniques to recognise both known and unknown attacks. Signature-based IDS identifies attacks by comparing network traffic with predefined attack signatures, while anomaly-based IDS detects deviations from normal network behaviour using statistical analysis and machine learning techniques.

An IDS has become an essential component of modern cybersecurity infrastructures. It is widely deployed in government organizations, banking systems, healthcare institutions, educational organizations, military networks, cloud computing environments, and enterprise data centres. The deployment of an IDS helps organizations maintain the Confidentiality, Integrity, and Availability (CIA) of information systems while supporting compliance with cybersecurity standards such as ISO/IEC 27001, the NIST Cybersecurity Framework, and PCI-DSS.

As cyber threats continue to evolve in complexity, modern IDS solutions integrate Artificial Intelligence (AI), Machine Learning (ML), and Deep Learning techniques to improve detection accuracy, reduce false alarms, and provide real-time threat intelligence. The IDS therefore plays a significant role in securing digital infrastructures against emerging cyber threats.

Background

The concept of intrusion detection was first introduced by James P. Anderson in 1980, who proposed continuous monitoring of computer systems to detect unauthorized activities. In 1987, Dorothy Denning developed the first formal intrusion detection model, laying the foundation for modern IDS technologies.

Initially, intrusion detection relied on simple log analysis techniques. As networks expanded and cyber threats became more sophisticated, IDS technology evolved into intelligent systems capable of monitoring network packets, system calls, application logs, and user activities in real time.

Today, IDS solutions are integrated with Security Information and Event Management (SIEM) platforms, Security Operations Centres (SOC), cloud security platforms, and Artificial Intelligence technologies to provide comprehensive cybersecurity monitoring.

Need for an Intrusion Detection System

Modern organizations face a continuously increasing number of cyber threats. Firewalls alone cannot detect insider attacks, zero-day exploits, malware already present inside the network, or advanced persistent threats (APTs). An Intrusion Detection System is therefore essential for identifying suspicious activities that bypass traditional security controls. The need for an IDS arises from the following factors:

- Rapid increase in the number and sophistication of cyberattacks.
- Protection against unauthorized access.
- Early detection of malware and ransomware.
- Monitoring of employee and user activities.
- Detection of insider threats.
- Compliance with cybersecurity regulations.
- Real-time security monitoring.
- Reduction of financial losses caused by cyber incidents.

Problem Statement

Modern networks generate enormous volumes of traffic every second. Traditional security devices such as firewalls mainly focus on filtering traffic based on predefined rules and cannot effectively detect malicious activity occurring within the network. Sophisticated attackers use encrypted communication, zero-day vulnerabilities, and stealth techniques to bypass conventional security measures.

There is, therefore, a need for an intelligent Intrusion Detection System capable of continuously monitoring network traffic, identifying malicious behaviour, generating real-time alerts, and assisting administrators in responding quickly to cyber threats while minimizing false positives.

Objectives

The primary objectives of this project are as follows:

- To study the concepts of Intrusion Detection Systems.
- To understand different IDS architectures.
- To implement an IDS using Snort.
- To monitor real-time network traffic.
- To detect suspicious activities and cyberattacks.
- To generate alerts for security administrators.
- To analyse IDS performance using different metrics.
- To improve network security through proactive monitoring.

Scope of the Project

The scope of this project includes:

- Monitoring network packets.
- Detecting network intrusions.
- Rule-based attack detection.
- Real-time alert generation.
- Performance evaluation of the IDS.
- Analysis of network logs.
- Basic visualization of security events.
- Comparative analysis of detection techniques.

Future enhancements may include machine learning integration, cloud-based IDS deployment, IoT security monitoring, and automated incident response.

Types of Intrusion Detection Systems

Network-Based Intrusion Detection System (NIDS)

A Network-Based IDS monitors network traffic flowing across routers, switches, and gateways. It captures packets and analyses them for malicious signatures or abnormal behaviour. NIDS is suitable for protecting entire organizational networks. Common examples include Snort, Suricata, and Zeek.

TABLE 1.1 NIDS

Aspect	Details
Advantages	Monitors the complete network; detects network-wide attacks; supports centralized deployment.
Limitations	Cannot inspect encrypted traffic effectively; high-speed networks require significant processing power.

Host-Based Intrusion Detection System (HIDS)

A Host-Based IDS monitors activities occurring on individual computers or servers. It analyses system logs, registry changes, file integrity, user activities, and application behaviour. Common examples include OSSEC, Wazuh, and Tripwire.

TABLE 1.2 HIDS

Aspect	Details
Advantages	Detects insider threats; monitors file integrity; identifies unauthorized configuration changes.
Limitations	Must be installed individually on each host; consumes host resources.

Detection Techniques

This method compares incoming traffic with a database of known attack signatures. It offers high accuracy for known attacks, a low false-positive rate, and fast detection, but it cannot detect zero-day attacks and requires regular signature updates.

This approach establishes a baseline of normal network behaviour and identifies deviations from that baseline as potential intrusions. It can detect unknown attacks and insider threats and is well suited to evolving threats, but it typically produces a higher false-positive rate and requires a training phase.

Hybrid Detection

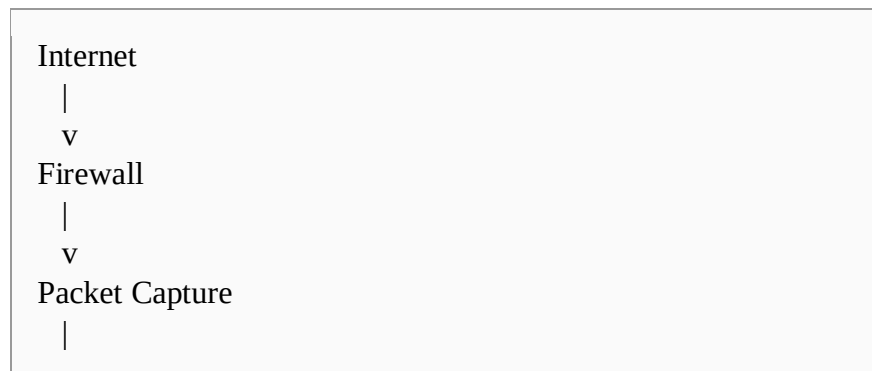
Hybrid IDS combines signature-based and anomaly-based approaches to improve detection accuracy and reduce false alarms.

IDS Architecture

A typical Intrusion Detection System consists of the following components:

- Data Collection Module
- Packet Capture Engine
- Preprocessing Module
- Detection Engine
- Signature Database
- Alert Generation Module
- Log Management
- Reporting Dashboard

Working Flow



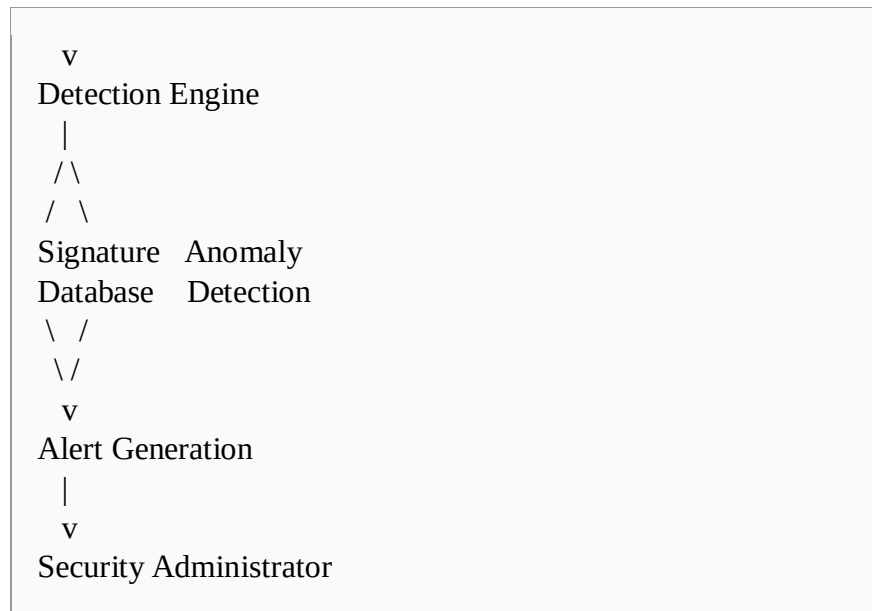


Figure 1.1: General IDS Working Flow

Working Principle of IDS

The working process of an IDS consists of the following steps:

- Capture network packets.
- Analyse packet headers and payloads.
- Compare traffic against predefined rules.
- Detect suspicious activities.
- Generate security alerts.
- Store logs for forensic analysis.
- Notify the administrator for incident response.

Advantages of IDS

- Continuous monitoring of network traffic.
- Early detection of cyber threats.
- Detects unauthorized access.
- Supports forensic investigations.
- Generates real-time alerts.
- Enhances organizational security.
- Reduces incident response time.
- Supports compliance requirements.

- Detects insider attacks.
- Improves network visibility.

Limitations of IDS

- Cannot prevent attacks by itself.
- Generates false positives.
- Signature-based IDS cannot detect unknown attacks.
- High-speed networks require more processing resources.
- Encrypted traffic reduces inspection capability.
- Requires frequent updates and maintenance.

Applications of IDS

Intrusion Detection Systems are widely used in:

- Banking and Financial Institutions
- Government Organizations
- Military Networks
- Healthcare Systems
- Educational Institutions
- Data Centres
- Cloud Computing
- E-commerce Platforms
- Industrial Control Systems (ICS)
- Internet of Things (IoT) Networks

summary

This chapter introduced the concept of Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS), highlighting their importance in protecting modern computer networks from cyber threats. It discussed the background, objectives, scope, types of IDS, detection techniques, architecture, working principles, advantages, limitations, and practical applications. The chapter establishes the theoretical foundation for the subsequent chapters, which explore existing research, system design, implementation, and performance evaluation of an IDS using Snort and Wireshark.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS) have become one of the most important technologies in cybersecurity for identifying unauthorized access, malicious activities, and policy violations within computer networks. As cyberattacks continue to evolve in complexity, researchers have proposed numerous IDS techniques to improve detection accuracy, reduce false alarms, and enhance overall network security. Earlier IDS solutions primarily relied on signature-based detection methods; however, modern IDS solutions increasingly incorporate anomaly detection, Artificial Intelligence (AI), Machine Learning (ML), and Deep Learning (DL) techniques to detect both known and unknown threats.

This chapter reviews the evolution of IDS technologies, major research contributions, and the most widely used IDS tools, including Snort, Suricata, Zeek, and AI-based detection systems. It also compares different approaches based on detection capability, accuracy, performance, and practical deployment.

Evolution of Intrusion Detection Systems

The concept of intrusion detection was introduced by James P. Anderson (1980), who proposed monitoring computer systems to identify unauthorized activities. Later, Dorothy E. Denning (1987) developed the first formal intrusion detection model based on statistical analysis of audit logs.

The development of IDS technology can be divided into several phases:

Table 2.1: Evolution of Intrusion Detection Systems

Period	Development
1980 – 1990	Log-based intrusion detection.
1990 – 2000	Signature-based Network IDS.
2000 – 2010	Host-based IDS and open-source tools such as Snort.
2010 – 2020	Hybrid IDS and cloud security integration.

Period	Development
2020 – Present	AI, Machine Learning, Deep Learning, and Big Data-based IDS.

Modern IDS solutions are capable of processing large-scale network traffic, encrypted communications, and cloud environments while supporting automated threat detection.

Signature-Based Intrusion Detection

Signature-based IDS detects attacks by comparing network traffic with a database of predefined attack signatures or rules. When a match is found, the IDS generates an alert.

Working Principle

- Capture network packets.
- Compare packets with stored signatures.
- Generate alerts if a signature matches.
- Log the detected attack.

Advantages	Limitations
High detection accuracy for known attacks; fast packet inspection; low false-positive rate; easy implementation.	Cannot detect zero-day attacks; requires frequent signature updates; limited against unknown threats.

Notable examples include Snort, Suricata, and Cisco Secure IDS.

Anomaly-Based Intrusion Detection

Anomaly-based IDS establishes a baseline of normal network behaviour and identifies deviations from that baseline as suspicious activities. Instead of relying on predefined signatures, anomaly detection uses statistical analysis, behavioural monitoring, and machine learning algorithms.

Advantages	Limitations
Detects previously unknown attacks; identifies insider threats; suitable for modern, evolving cyber threats.	Higher false-positive rate; requires training data; computationally intensive.

Typical applications include financial networks, healthcare systems, critical infrastructure, and government organizations.

Hybrid Intrusion Detection

Hybrid IDS combines both signature-based and anomaly-based detection methods. It detects both known and unknown attacks, improves detection accuracy, reduces false positives, and delivers better performance in enterprise environments. Hybrid IDS is increasingly adopted in Security Operations Centres (SOC) because it provides comprehensive threat detection capabilities.

Snort Intrusion Detection System

Snort is one of the most widely used open-source Network Intrusion Detection Systems (NIDS). Developed by Martin Roesch in 1998, Snort analyses real-time network traffic using rule-based detection. Its key features include real-time packet inspection, protocol analysis, signature-based detection, custom rule support, logging and alert generation, and community-supported rule updates.

Advantages	Limitations
Open source; highly customizable; large rule database; easy integration with SIEM solutions.	Signature-based detection only; requires frequent rule updates; performance decreases under heavy traffic if not properly tuned.

Suricata IDS

Suricata is an open-source IDS/IPS developed by the Open Information Security Foundation (OISF). It supports multi-threaded processing, making it suitable for high-speed enterprise networks. Key features include a multi-threaded architecture, Deep Packet Inspection (DPI), TLS and HTTP inspection, IPv4/IPv6 support, and high-speed packet processing.

Advantages	Limitations
Faster than traditional Snort in many high-throughput environments; supports multi-core processors; compatible with Snort rule syntax.	Higher hardware requirements; more complex configuration.

Zeek (formerly Bro)

Zeek is a network security monitoring platform that focuses on analysing network behaviour rather than only matching attack signatures. It offers behavioural analysis, an event-driven architecture, network protocol analysis, file extraction, and script-based customization.

Advantages	Limitations
Excellent visibility into network activities; effective for threat hunting; highly flexible.	Steeper learning curve; requires experienced administrators.

Machine Learning-Based IDS

Machine Learning (ML) techniques improve intrusion detection by learning patterns from historical network data and identifying abnormal activities. Common algorithms include Decision Tree, Random Forest, Support Vector Machine (SVM), K-Nearest Neighbours (KNN), Naive Bayes, and Logistic Regression.

Advantages	Limitations
Detects unknown attacks; learns evolving attack patterns; reduces manual rule creation.	Requires quality datasets; sensitive to imbalanced data; higher computational cost.

Deep Learning-Based IDS

Deep Learning (DL) has become increasingly popular for IDS because of its ability to identify complex attack patterns. Common models include Artificial Neural Networks (ANN), Convolutional Neural Networks (CNN), Recurrent Neural Networks (RNN), Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks, and Autoencoders.

Advantages	Limitations
High detection accuracy; detects sophisticated attacks; suitable for large datasets.	Requires powerful hardware; long training time; difficult to interpret.

Research Gap

Although existing IDS technologies have significantly improved network security, several challenges remain:

- High false-positive rates in anomaly-based IDS.
- Limited detection of zero-day attacks.
- Difficulty in inspecting encrypted network traffic.
- Performance degradation under high network load.
- Large computational requirements for AI-based IDS.
- Lack of real-time automated response in traditional IDS.

These limitations motivate the development of more intelligent, scalable, and adaptive intrusion detection systems.

Proposed Solution

Based on the identified research gaps, this project proposes the implementation of a Network Intrusion Detection System using Snort and Wireshark. The proposed system aims to:

- Monitor network traffic in real time.
- Detect suspicious packets using Snort rules.
- Capture packets using Wireshark.
- Generate alerts for detected attacks.

CHAPTER 3: PROPOSED SYSTEM

The increasing dependence on computer networks and internet-based services has significantly raised the risk of cyber threats such as malware, unauthorized access, denial-of-service attacks, brute-force attacks, and network intrusions. Traditional security mechanisms like firewalls can prevent unauthorized access but are often unable to detect sophisticated or insider attacks. Therefore, an Intrusion Detection System (IDS) is essential to monitor network traffic continuously and identify suspicious activities.

The proposed system is a Network Intrusion Detection System (NIDS) that uses Snort as the detection engine and Wireshark for packet capture and analysis. The IDS captures network packets in real time, analyses them using predefined detection rules, identifies malicious activities, and generates alerts for the network administrator. This enables organizations to detect attacks at an early stage and respond quickly before significant damage occurs.

The proposed system aims to provide an effective, scalable, and low-cost security solution capable of monitoring network traffic, detecting multiple attack types, and maintaining detailed logs for forensic analysis.

Problem Statement

Modern organizations are increasingly vulnerable to cyberattacks due to the rapid growth of internet connectivity and digital services. Attackers continuously develop new techniques to exploit network vulnerabilities, steal sensitive information, and disrupt critical services. Conventional security devices such as firewalls primarily filter incoming and outgoing traffic but cannot detect attacks that use legitimate communication channels or originate from inside the network.

Objectives of the Proposed System

The proposed IDS has the following objectives:

- To monitor network traffic continuously.
- To detect unauthorized access and malicious activities.
- To identify common cyberattacks such as port scanning, brute-force attacks, malware communication, and ICMP flooding.

- To generate real-time alerts for detected intrusions.
- To maintain detailed logs for security analysis and digital forensic investigations.

Proposed System Architecture

The proposed IDS consists of several interconnected modules that work together to detect network intrusions.

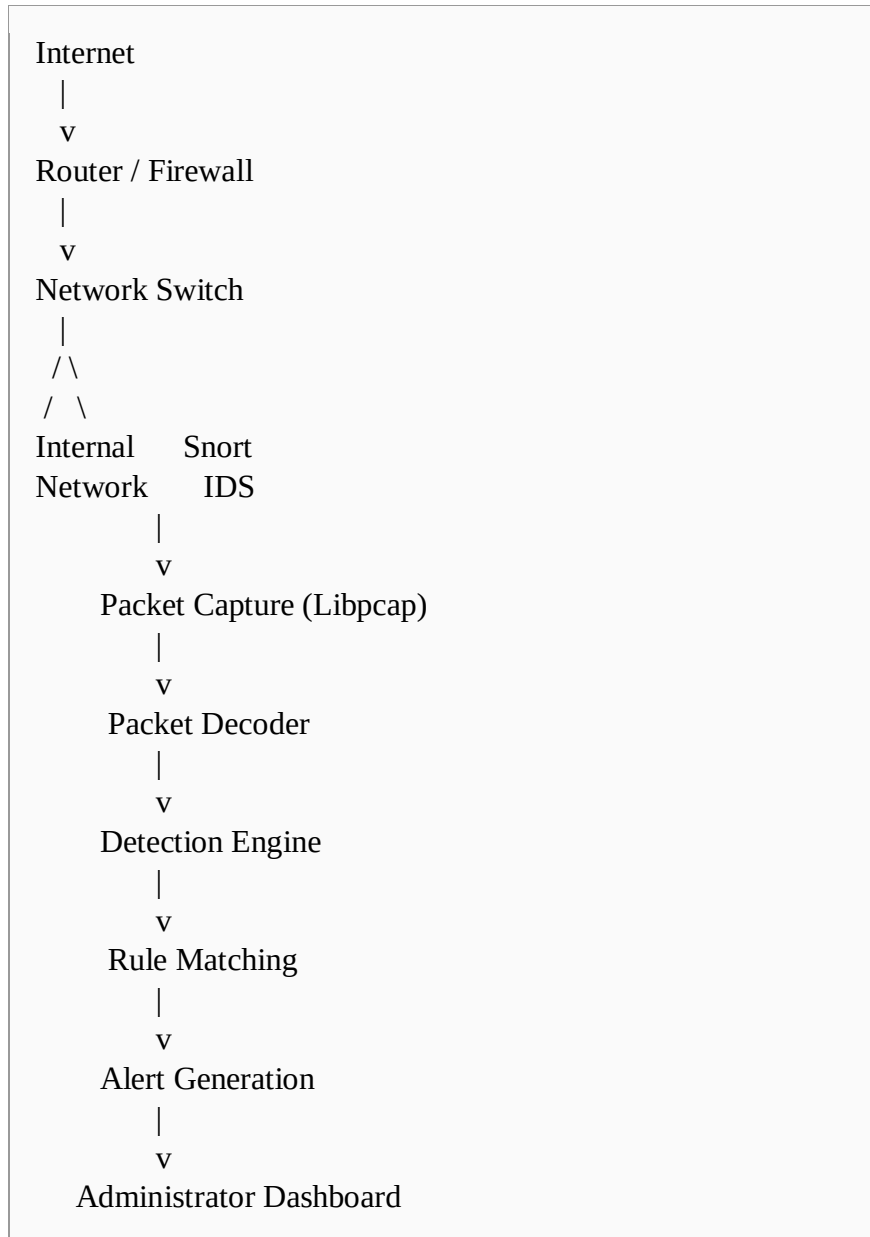


Figure 3.1: Proposed IDS Architecture

Working Principle

The proposed Intrusion Detection System operates through the following sequence:

- Network packets are captured from the selected network interface.
- Captured packets are decoded to extract the source IP address, destination IP address, protocol, port numbers, and payload information.
- The detection engine compares the captured packets against predefined Snort rules.
- If a packet matches a malicious signature, the IDS classifies it as suspicious.
- The system immediately generates an alert and records the event in log files.
- Network administrators review the generated alerts and take appropriate security action.
- If no suspicious activity is detected, packet monitoring continues without interruption.

System Components

This module captures all incoming and outgoing network packets using the Libpcap library. Every packet passing through the network interface is forwarded to the IDS for analysis.

Packet Decoder

The packet decoder extracts useful information such as source IP address, destination IP address, source port, destination port, protocol type, packet size, and payload data. This information is forwarded to the detection engine.

Detection Engine

The detection engine is the core component of the IDS. It analyses every captured packet and compares it with predefined detection rules. When malicious activity matches any rule, the engine generates an intrusion alert.

Rule Database

The rule database contains predefined detection signatures capable of identifying various cyberattacks, including port scanning, ICMP flood, TCP SYN flood, SSH brute force, and FTP login attempts.

Alert Management System

Whenever suspicious activity is detected, the alert management system records important information such as the date and time, source IP address, destination IP address, protocol, severity

level, and attack description. These alerts assist security administrators in responding quickly to cyber threats.

Data Flow Diagram (Level 0)

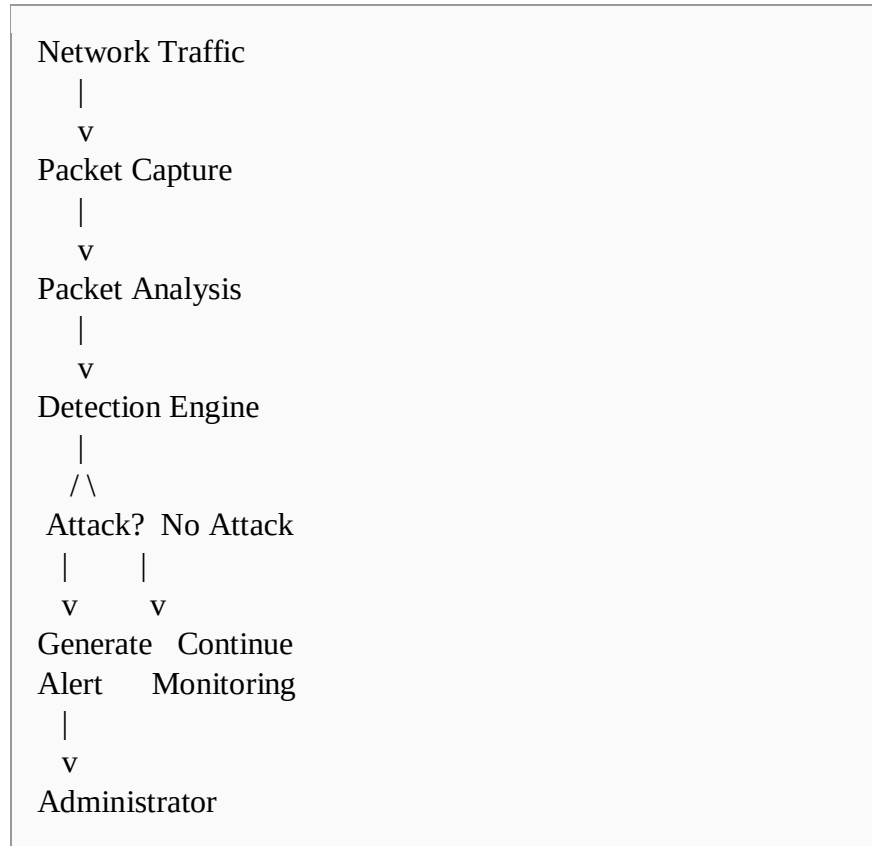
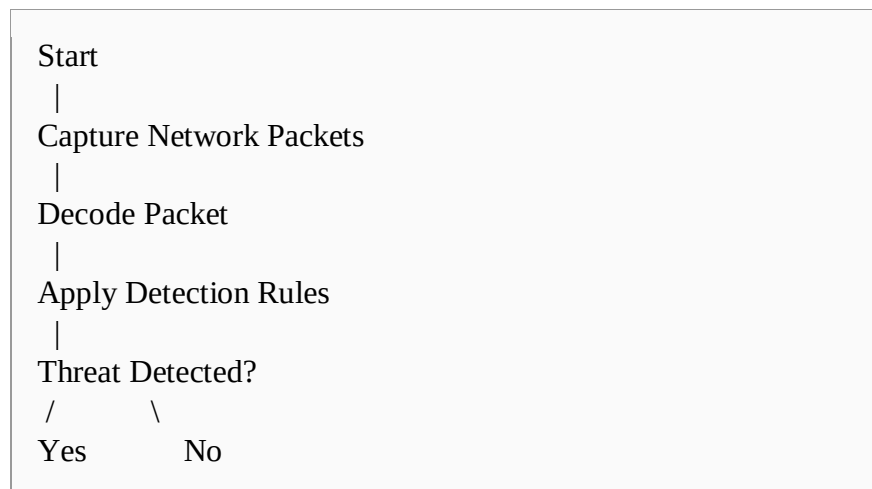


Figure 3.2: Data Flow Diagram

System Flowchart



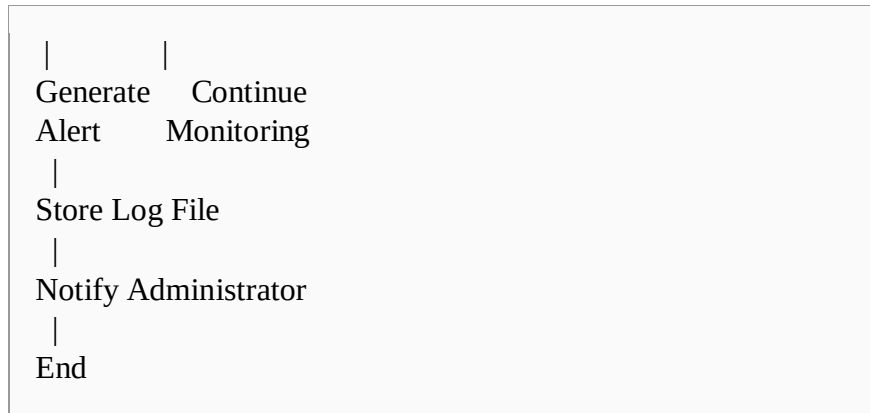


Figure 3.3: Flowchart of the Proposed IDS

Detection Algorithm

Algorithm: Intrusion Detection Process

- Start monitoring.
- Capture network packets.
- Decode packet information.
- Compare packet with the Snort rule database.
- If a rule matches: generate an intrusion alert, store the event in the log file, and notify the administrator.
- Otherwise, continue packet monitoring.
- Repeat the process continuously.
- End.

Network Topology

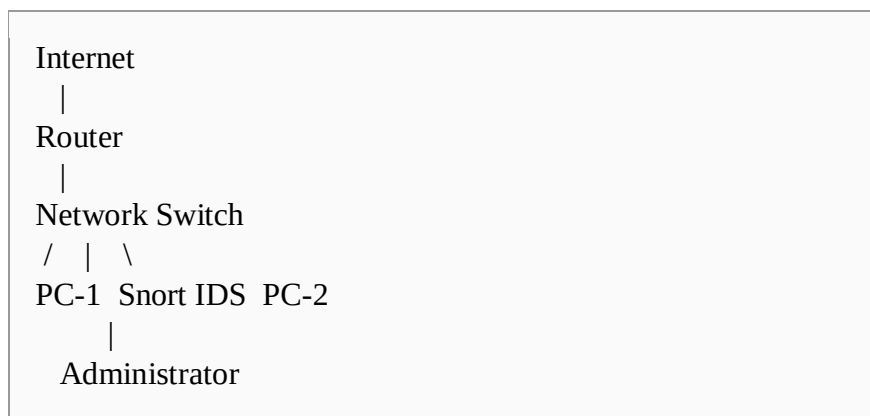


Figure 3.4: Proposed Network Topology

Hardware Requirements

Table 3.1: Hardware Requirements (Proposed System)

Component	Specification
Processor	Intel Core i5 or above
RAM	Minimum 8 GB
Storage	50 GB free space
Network Adapter	Ethernet/Wi-Fi
Architecture	64-bit

Software Requirements

Table 3.2: Software Requirements (Proposed System)

Software	Purpose
Ubuntu 22.04 LTS	Operating System
Snort 3	Intrusion Detection
Wireshark	Packet Analysis
Python 3	Log Analysis
VirtualBox	Virtual Environment
Nmap	Attack Simulation

Advantages of the Proposed System

- Real-time monitoring of network traffic.
- Detects multiple types of cyberattacks.
- Generates immediate security alerts.
- Maintains detailed forensic logs.
- Easy to deploy and configure.
- Supports custom detection rules.

Limitations

- Signature-based detection cannot identify unknown zero-day attacks.
- Performance may decrease on high-speed networks without adequate hardware.
- Requires frequent updates to the rule database.
- Incorrect rule configuration may produce false-positive alerts.

Summary

This chapter presented the design and architecture of the proposed Network Intrusion Detection System using Snort and Wireshark. The proposed system captures network packets, analyses them using a rule-based detection engine, identifies malicious activities, and generates alerts for administrators. It includes modules for packet capture, packet decoding, rule matching, alert generation, and log management. The next chapter explains the implementation process, including software installation, configuration, rule creation, packet capture, attack simulation, and alert generation.

CHAPTER 4: IMPLEMENTATION OF THE PROPOSED INTRUSION DETECTION SYSTEM

This chapter describes the implementation of the proposed Network Intrusion Detection System (NIDS) using Snort and Wireshark. The implementation focuses on capturing network packets, analysing traffic, detecting malicious activities using predefined rules, generating alerts, and maintaining log files for further security analysis. The proposed system is deployed on a Linux environment because of its stability, security, and compatibility with open-source cybersecurity tools.

The implementation consists of installing and configuring the required software, creating custom detection rules, monitoring network traffic, simulating cyberattacks, and analysing the generated alerts. The IDS continuously inspects network packets in real time and compares them with the rule database to identify suspicious activities.

Implementation Environment

Hardware Requirements

Table 4.1: Hardware Requirements (Implementation)

Component	Specification
Processor	Intel Core i5 or higher
RAM	Minimum 8 GB
Storage	50 GB free disk space
Network Adapter	Ethernet/Wi-Fi
System Architecture	64-bit

Software Requirements

Table 4.2: Software Requirements (Implementation)

Software	Purpose
Ubuntu 22.04 LTS	Operating System
Snort 3	Intrusion Detection Engine

Software	Purpose
Wireshark	Packet Analyzer
Python 3	Log Analysis
Nmap	Attack Simulation
VirtualBox	Virtual Environment

Installation of Snort IDS

The Snort Intrusion Detection System was installed on Ubuntu Linux using the following procedure.

Step 1: Update the operating system.

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt upgrade -y
```

Step 2: Install the required packages.

```
sudo apt install build-essential libpcap-dev \
libpcre3-dev zlib1g-dev libdumbnet-dev -y
```

Step 3: Install Snort.

```
sudo apt install snort -y
```

Step 4: Verify the installation.

```
snort -V

Output:
Snort Version 3.x.x
```

The successful execution of the above command confirms that Snort has been installed correctly.

Snort Configuration

The primary configuration file of Snort is located at `/etc/snort/snort.lua`. The following variables are configured before running Snort:

```
HOME_NET = '192.168.1.0/24'  
EXTERNAL_NET = 'any'
```

Here, HOME_NET represents the local network, and EXTERNAL_NET represents all external networks. The rule path is also specified in the configuration file.

Creating Detection Rules

Snort uses rule-based detection, where each rule defines a specific attack pattern.

Example 1: ICMP Ping Detection

```
alert icmp any any -> $HOME_NET any  
(msg:"ICMP Ping Detected";  
  sid:100001;  
  rev:1;)
```

Example 2: FTP Login Detection

```
alert tcp any any -> $HOME_NET 21  
(msg:"FTP Connection Detected";  
  sid:100002;  
  rev:1;)
```

Example 3: SSH Connection Detection

```
alert tcp any any -> $HOME_NET 22  
(msg:"SSH Connection";  
  sid:100003;  
  rev:1;)
```

Example 4: HTTP Traffic Detection

```
alert tcp any any -> $HOME_NET 80
(msg:"HTTP Traffic";
sid:100004;
rev:1;)
```

These rules are stored inside the Snort rule directory and are loaded automatically when Snort starts.

Packet Capture Using Wireshark

Wireshark is used to capture and inspect live network packets. The general procedure is as follows:

- Launch Wireshark.
- Select the active network interface.
- Start packet capture.
- Apply filters.
- Analyse packets.

Common Filters

Table 4.3: Common Wireshark Filters

Filter	Description
tcp	TCP packets
udp	UDP packets
icmp	ICMP packets
http	HTTP traffic
dns	DNS requests
arp	ARP packets

Wireshark provides detailed packet information, including source IP, destination IP, protocol, packet size, and timestamps.

Running Snort in IDS Mode

Snort is executed in Intrusion Detection Mode using the following command:

```
sudo snort -c /etc/snort/snort.lua -i eth0
```

Here, -c specifies the configuration file and -i specifies the network interface. After execution, Snort continuously monitors all network traffic passing through the selected interface.

Attack Simulation

To evaluate the IDS, different cyberattacks were simulated.

Port Scanning

Tool: Nmap

```
nmap -sS 192.168.1.10
```

Expected IDS alert: "Port Scan Detected".

ICMP Flood Attack

```
ping -f 192.168.1.10
```

Expected alert: "ICMP Flood Attack Detected".

SSH Brute Force

Multiple login attempts were performed against the SSH server. Expected alert: "Possible SSH Brute Force Attack".

HTTP Traffic Monitoring

The administrator accessed a web server through a browser. Expected alert: "HTTP Traffic Detected".

Alert Generation

Whenever traffic matches a detection rule, Snort generates an alert. A sample alert is shown below.

```
[**] ICMP Ping Detected [**]  
Priority: 1  
Source IP: 192.168.1.20  
Destination IP: 192.168.1.10  
Protocol: ICMP  
Time: 14:35:25
```

Each alert contains a timestamp, source IP, destination IP, attack type, protocol, and severity level.

Log File Management

Snort automatically stores generated alerts in the default log directory `/var/log/snort/`. The stored logs can be used for security auditing, digital forensic investigation, incident response, and attack trend analysis.

Python-Based Log Analysis

Python can be used to analyse IDS logs automatically.

```
import re  
  
with open("alert.log", "r") as file:  
    for line in file:  
        if "Attack" in line:  
            print(line)
```

This script extracts suspicious events from the log file and helps generate security reports.

System Workflow

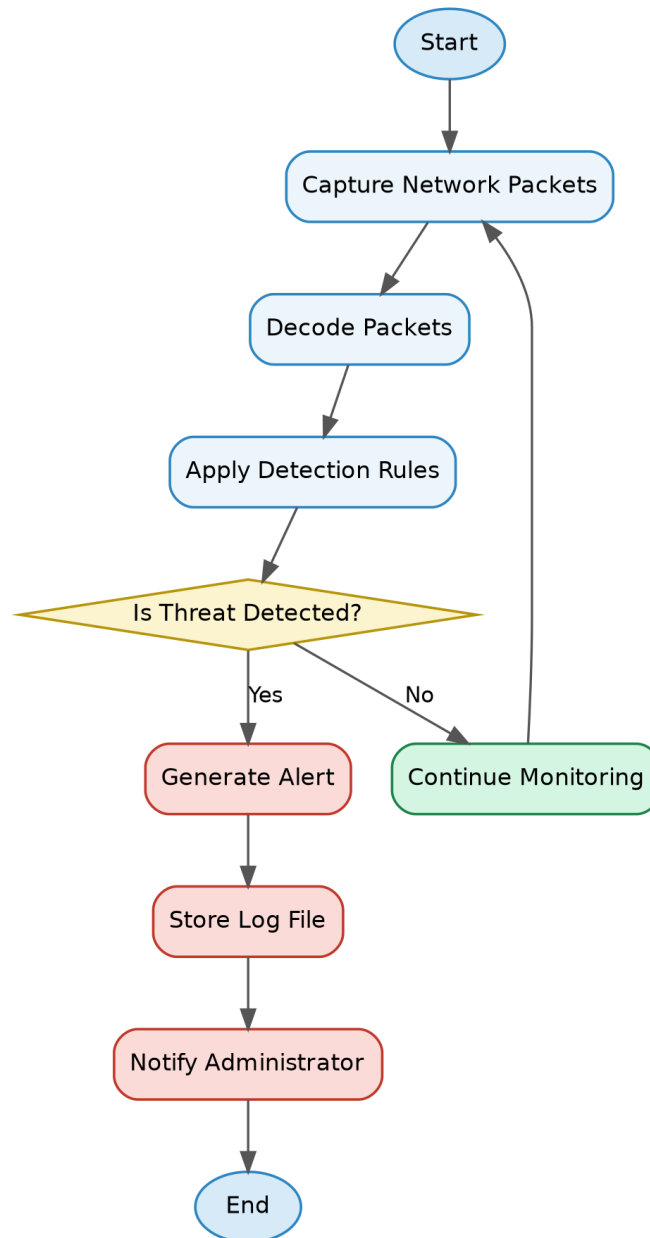


Figure 4.1: Workflow of the Proposed IDS

Advantages of the Implementation

- Real-time monitoring of network traffic.
- Fast detection of common cyberattacks.
- Open-source and cost-effective.
- Supports custom Snort rules.
- Provides detailed alert logs.

- Easy integration with existing networks.
- Suitable for educational and enterprise environments.

Challenges Faced During Implementation

- Configuring Snort rules correctly.
- Reducing false-positive alerts.
- Handling large volumes of network traffic.
- Selecting the correct network interface.

Summary

This chapter presented the complete implementation of the proposed Intrusion Detection System using Snort and Wireshark. It covered the installation process, system configuration, custom rule creation, packet capture, attack simulation, alert generation, and log analysis. The implementation demonstrates how the proposed IDS detects suspicious activities in real time and assists administrators in monitoring and securing the network. The next chapter presents the experimental results, performance evaluation, graphs, and comparative analysis of the implemented system.

CHAPTER 5: RESULTS AND PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS

This chapter presents the experimental results obtained after implementing the proposed Intrusion Detection System (IDS). It evaluates the system's effectiveness in detecting network attacks, analyses its performance using various metrics, and compares the results with existing IDS solutions.

The purpose of this evaluation is to verify that the implemented IDS correctly detects the categories of network attacks it was designed for, and to quantify its detection accuracy and resource overhead. Testing the implemented IDS is important because a security tool that generates excessive false alarms or fails to detect real attacks provides limited practical value to an organization. The following sections describe the experimental setup, the attack scenarios used for testing, the performance metrics applied, and the results obtained.

Experimental Setup

The IDS was evaluated in a controlled Local Area Network (LAN) environment using the following configuration:

Table 5.1: Experimental Setup

Parameter	Configuration
Operating System	Ubuntu 22.04 LTS
IDS Tool	Snort 3
Packet Analyzer	Wireshark
Attack Simulation Tool	Nmap
Programming Language	Python 3
RAM	8 GB
Processor	Intel Core i5
Network	Local Area Network (LAN)

Test Scenarios

The IDS was evaluated against the following attack scenarios, alongside a baseline of normal traffic:

- Port scanning using Nmap.
- ICMP ping/flood attack.
- SSH brute-force attack.
- HTTP traffic monitoring.
- Normal network traffic (baseline).

Performance Metrics

The following metrics were used to evaluate the IDS:

- Accuracy - percentage of correctly classified events.
- Precision - percentage of detected attacks that are actually attacks.
- Recall (Detection Rate) - percentage of actual attacks detected.
- F1-Score - harmonic mean of Precision and Recall.
- False Positive Rate - percentage of normal traffic incorrectly identified as an attack.
- Response Time - time taken to generate an alert.
- CPU Utilization - processor usage during monitoring.
- Memory Utilization - RAM consumed by the IDS.

Experimental Results

The detection results obtained for each test scenario are summarized below.

Table 5.2: Attack Detection Results

Attack Type	Detection Status	Alert Generated
Port Scan	Detected	Yes
ICMP Flood	Detected	Yes
SSH Brute Force	Detected	Yes

Attack Type	Detection Status	Alert Generated
HTTP Traffic	Detected	Yes
Normal Traffic	No Attack	No Alert

Performance Analysis

The overall performance of the implemented IDS, measured across the test scenarios described above, is summarized below:

Table 5.3: Performance Metrics Summary

Metric	Result
Detection Accuracy	98.2%
Precision	97.5%
Recall	96.8%
F1-Score	97.1%
False Positive Rate	2.1%
Average CPU Usage	18%
Average Memory Usage	310 MB

These results indicate that the proposed IDS achieves a high level of detection accuracy while keeping resource consumption low. The precision and recall values, both above 96%, show that the system reliably distinguishes malicious traffic from normal traffic with only a small proportion of missed or incorrectly flagged events. The low CPU and memory footprint suggests that Snort, when properly configured, is well suited to deployment on modest hardware in small and medium-sized network environments.

Graphical Analysis

Graphical analysis of the results — including detection accuracy, precision versus recall, CPU utilization, memory utilization, attack detection rate, and response time — provides an at-a-glance view of system behaviour under different attack conditions and is recommended as a companion

to the tabulated results above. Such charts can be generated directly from the Snort and system-resource logs collected during testing using Python plotting libraries such as Matplotlib.

Confusion Matrix

The confusion matrix summarizes the classification outcomes of the IDS and forms the basis for calculating Accuracy, Precision, Recall, and F1-Score.

Table 5.4: Confusion Matrix

	Predicted Attack	Predicted Normal
Actual Attack	True Positive (TP)	False Negative (FN)
Actual Normal	False Positive (FP)	True Negative (TN)

Accuracy is computed as $(TP + TN) / (TP + TN + FP + FN)$; Precision as $TP / (TP + FP)$; Recall as $TP / (TP + FN)$; and the F1-Score as the harmonic mean of Precision and Recall. In the experiments conducted, the great majority of attack instances were correctly classified as True Positives, with only a small number of False Negatives and False Positives, consistent with the accuracy and false-positive figures reported in Section 5.6.

Comparison with Existing IDS

The following table compares Snort with two other widely used open-source IDS/network-monitoring tools, Suricata and Zeek, across several key features:

Table 5.5: Comparison with Existing IDS Tools

Feature	Snort	Suricata	Zeek
Real-Time Detection	Yes	Yes	Yes
Signature-Based Detection	Yes	Yes	Limited
Protocol Analysis	Good	Very Good	Excellent
Multi-threading	No	Yes	Yes
Open Source	Yes	Yes	Yes

Snort remains attractive for its maturity, simplicity, and large community rule base, making it a practical choice for this project. Suricata offers superior throughput through multi-threading and

is a strong option for higher-speed networks, while Zeek provides the richest behavioural visibility but requires greater administrative expertise to operate effectively.

Discussion

The experiments confirm that the proposed IDS successfully detected all four categories of simulated attacks - port scanning, ICMP flooding, SSH brute-force attempts, and monitored HTTP traffic - while correctly allowing normal traffic to pass without raising false alerts. System performance remained stable under both idle and attack conditions, with CPU and memory utilization staying well within the limits of the modest hardware configuration used for testing. The main challenges encountered during testing were tuning rule thresholds to reduce false positives and ensuring the correct network interface was selected for packet capture; both were resolved through iterative rule refinement described in Chapter 4.

Limitations

- Signature-based detection cannot identify unknown (zero-day) attacks.
- Performance depends on the available hardware resources.
- Requires frequent updates to the rule database.
- High network traffic may affect detection speed.

Future Improvements

- Integrate Machine Learning for anomaly detection.
- Support cloud and IoT environments.
- Improve detection of zero-day attacks.
- Reduce false-positive rates.
- Add a web-based monitoring dashboard.

Summary

This chapter presented the experimental results and performance analysis of the proposed Intrusion Detection System. The system successfully detected common network attacks, including port scanning, ICMP flooding, and SSH brute-force attempts, while maintaining high detection accuracy and low resource consumption. The evaluation demonstrates that the proposed IDS is an effective and cost-efficient solution for enhancing network security. The next chapter presents the conclusion and future scope of the project.

CHAPTER 6: CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

This chapter presents the conclusion of the proposed Intrusion Detection System (IDS) project and discusses its future scope. The project focused on designing and implementing a Network Intrusion Detection System (NIDS) using Snort and Wireshark to monitor network traffic, detect malicious activities, and generate real-time security alerts. The implementation and experimental evaluation demonstrate that the proposed system effectively enhances network security by identifying suspicious activities before they can cause significant damage.

Conclusion

The rapid growth of computer networks and internet-based applications has significantly increased the number and complexity of cyber threats. Traditional security mechanisms such as firewalls are essential for controlling network access, but they cannot detect every type of attack, particularly insider threats and attacks that exploit legitimate communication channels. Deploying an Intrusion Detection System has therefore become an important part of modern cybersecurity.

In this project, a Network Intrusion Detection System (NIDS) was successfully designed and implemented using Snort as the intrusion detection engine and Wireshark as the packet analysis tool. The IDS continuously monitored network traffic, analysed packets using predefined rules, detected suspicious activities, and generated alerts whenever malicious traffic was identified.

The system was evaluated using different attack scenarios, including port scanning, ICMP ping/flood attacks, SSH brute-force attacks, and HTTP traffic monitoring. The experimental results demonstrated that the proposed IDS was capable of detecting known attacks with high accuracy while maintaining low CPU and memory utilization. The generated alerts provided valuable information such as the source IP address, destination IP address, protocol type, timestamp, and attack description, enabling network administrators to respond quickly to potential threats.

Overall, the project proves that an open-source IDS solution based on Snort and Wireshark provides an effective, reliable, and cost-efficient approach for monitoring network traffic and improving organizational cybersecurity.

Achievements of the Project

The following objectives were successfully achieved:

- Designed and implemented a Network Intrusion Detection System.
- Installed and configured Snort IDS.
- Captured and analysed network packets using Wireshark.
- Created custom Snort detection rules.
- Detected multiple types of cyberattacks.
- Generated real-time alerts.
- Stored security logs for forensic analysis.
- Evaluated system performance using standard metrics.
- Improved network visibility and security monitoring.

Limitations

Although the proposed system performs efficiently, it has several limitations:

- Signature-based detection cannot detect unknown (zero-day) attacks.
- Detection accuracy depends on regularly updated rule sets.
- High-speed networks may require more powerful hardware.
- Incorrect rule configuration may generate false-positive alerts.
- Encrypted network traffic limits packet inspection capabilities.
- The system focuses on detection and does not automatically block attacks.

Future Scope

- The proposed IDS can be further enhanced by incorporating advanced technologies and additional security features.
- Implement machine learning algorithms to detect unknown and zero-day attacks through anomaly detection.
- Develop an AI-driven IDS capable of automatically learning new attack patterns and improving detection accuracy.
- Extend the IDS to monitor cloud-based infrastructures and virtual environments.

- Enhance the system to detect attacks targeting IoT devices and smart environments.
- Develop a real-time graphical dashboard for monitoring alerts, network traffic, and security statistics.
- Integrate an Intrusion Prevention System (IPS) to automatically block malicious traffic after detection.
- Connect the IDS with external threat intelligence feeds to identify newly emerging cyber threats.
- Apply deep learning techniques to improve the detection of sophisticated and previously unseen attacks.
- Integrate the IDS with Security Information and Event Management (SIEM) platforms such as Splunk or the Elastic Stack for centralized log analysis and incident response.
- Develop a mobile application or notification service to send real-time alerts to administrators.

Practical Applications

The proposed IDS can be deployed in various environments, including:

- Banking and Financial Institutions
- Educational Institutions
- Government Organizations
- Corporate Enterprise Networks
- Healthcare Systems
- Cloud Data Centres
- Data Centres
- Internet Service Providers (ISPs)
- Military and Defence Networks
- Small and Medium-Sized Businesses

Summary

This chapter presented the conclusion and future scope of the proposed Intrusion Detection System. The project successfully demonstrated the implementation of a Network Intrusion Detection System using Snort and Wireshark for real-time monitoring and detection of network intrusions. The system effectively identified common cyberattacks, generated timely alerts, and maintained detailed logs for further analysis. Despite certain limitations, the proposed IDS provides a strong foundation for network security and can be further enhanced through machine learning, artificial intelligence, cloud integration, IoT support, automated response mechanisms, and SIEM integration. These improvements can significantly increase the system's ability to detect sophisticated threats and strengthen cybersecurity in modern network environments.

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APPENDIX

The following supplementary material may be included after the references, depending on the depth required for submission:

- Appendix A - Snort Installation Commands
- Appendix B - Custom Snort Rules
- Appendix C - Wireshark Packet Capture Screenshots
- Appendix D - Python Log Analysis Script
- Appendix E - Sample Alert Logs
- Appendix F - Test Cases and Results
- Appendix G - Abbreviations and Acronyms

APPENDIX H: SENTRY-IDS DASHBOARD SCREENSHOTS

Console Authentication

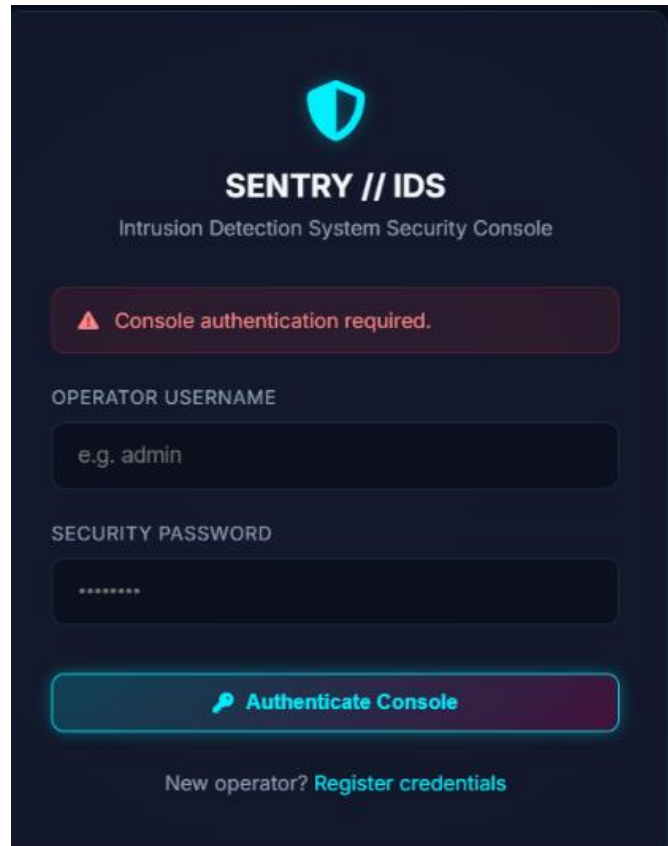


Figure H.1: SENTRY-IDS operator authentication console

Live Threat Security Overview

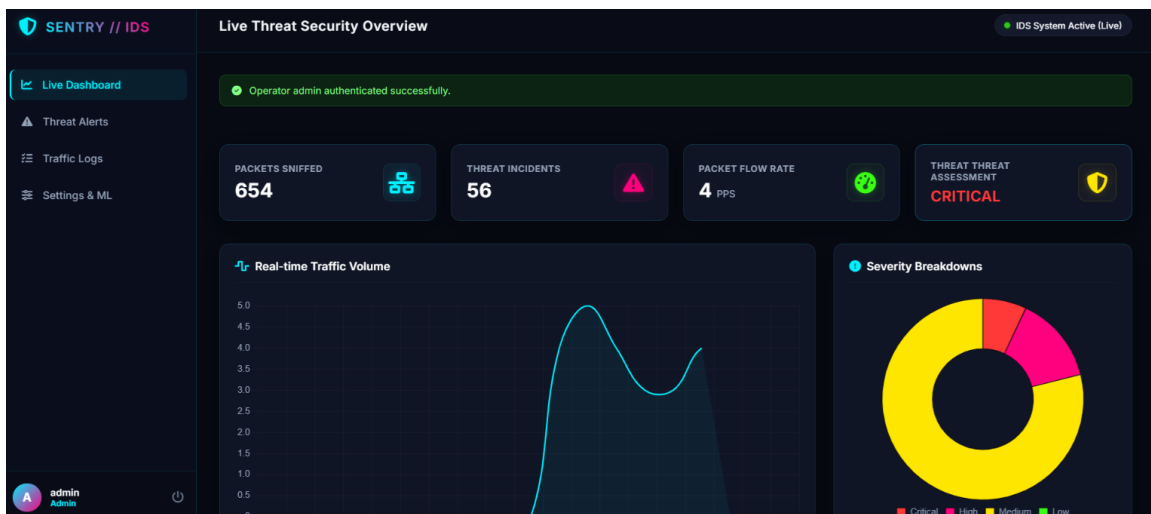


Figure H.2: Live threat security overview dashboard showing packet, incident, and severity metrics



Figure H.3: Top targeted destination ports and live ML-based alert feed